

A GLANCE AT THE PAST
AND PRESENT OF THE NEGRO

BY ROBERT H. TERRELL



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THE PAST AND PRESENT OF THE NEGRO: AN ADDRESS ***

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AN ADDRESS BY

ROBERT H. TERRELL



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A GLANCE AT THE PAST AND PRESENT OF THE NEGRO.

By ROBERT H. TERRELL.

MR. PRESIDENT, LADIES AND GENTLEMEN:

Two events in the history of our country take a foremost place among the great deeds of the world. The signing of the Declaration of Independence is one, and the promulgation of the Emancipation Proclamation is the other. In political importance both are unrivaled, and in moral grandeur both unsurpassed. The courage and patriotism of the men who wrote their names on the immortal document that brought on the Revolutionary War will always occupy as bright a page in the annals of our country as the prowess and fierce determination of the heroes who fought its battles on the field. When Abraham Lincoln, of blessed memory, signed the sacred document that gave to the Negro his freedom, he not only immortalized himself, but performed a deed that will live in history as long as the great military engagements of the Civil War. When with the stroke of his pen he broke the chains of four millions of human beings, he crowned his career with a halo of glory that will grow brighter and brighter to the end of time.

The signing of the Declaration of Independence brought on the war which culminated in victory for an oppressed people and in the establishment of our republican form of government. When the Colonial soldier returned to his fireside and laid down his implements of battle he found awaiting him a political system so moulded and vitalized that it secured to him his liberty and those rights which tend to dignify man. The ultimate results of the Revolutionary War were all that the patriots of 1776 had fought for, all that they had hoped for. They are today a blessed inheritance to their descendants. The American Republic is now in the front

ranks of great nations, and her white population the first in freedom of all people on earth.

The Emancipation Proclamation was a document far greater in its moral purpose than the Declaration of Independence, for there was in it more humanity and more Christianity. The Colonial fathers declared that all men are created equal—a beautifully wrought truth which meant everything for one part of the population but nothing for another part which was held in a cruel slavery. The historic paper which Lincoln gave to the world nearly a hundred years later abolished that slavery. It has not, however, fulfilled the wishes, the hopes, and the final expectations of those who pleaded so eloquently for the Negro on the rostrum, or those who fought so desperately on the field of battle to make its provisions effective. And our cup is all the more bitter, when the thought comes to us that among those who bled and died that the country might be saved and their kinsmen free were black men, the bravest soldiers that ever wore a uniform.

The denial of rights guaranteed the Negro by the Constitution and the refusal to grant him the ordinary privileges of a freeman have created what is called the “Negro Problem”—the most prominent, the gravest and the most important question in American affairs. Ten millions of people with African blood in their veins—“an undifferentiated part of the Nation”—are made the objects of the meanest discrimination and the most unjust treatment by a so-called superior race seven times their number. I can see for the American people no permanent peace, no ease of conscience until the Negro question is settled, and settled right.

At no time since the Civil War has the future of the Negro seemed so dark and so uncertain as today. We are in thick weather and on a stormy sea, and many wise and thoughtful people fear for our safety. But I believe behind the clouds the sun is shining and is bound to bring in God’s final day of light. The older ones among us have seen darker days than these. They have seen husbands sold from wives and children from mothers, yet they hoped on and prayed on until the day of their redemption came. And shall we with forty years of freedom behind us and forty years of opportunity to strengthen and develop us be less courageous than they were? It may be well for us to pause a moment and take a cursory glance at the history of the black man in America and see through what trials and through what

difficulties he has so triumphantly come. Such a review may be helpful to us and may make our present seem less gloomy and more hopeful.

In the year ^[1]1620 two ships from foreign shores set sail for America. Both carried passengers destined to play an important part in the history of our country. One came from England and landed her precious burden on the northern shore of Cape Cod. The other sailed from the sunny shores of Africa, touched at Jamestown in Virginia, and left there twenty black men as slaves. Those from England were the forerunners of a people distinguished for thrift, enterprise and ingenuity. To these pilgrims and their descendants the American nation is very largely indebted for its greatness. But that score of black men, unwilling emigrants, torn by force from their native land, were the fathers of a people who produced no such salutary effect upon the civilization with which they came in contact. They proved to be a hindrance to it rather than an advantage. They and their descendants were slaves. The labor which they performed lost its dignity and became degrading in the eyes of the white man in the section where these bondmen lived and toiled. The development of this spirit has been the great misfortune—the bane of the southern states, for nothing is more essential to the prosperity of a community than industry in all its citizens.

¹. Many writers say that slavery was introduced in the Colonies in 1619.

The germ of slavery that fell upon the soil of Virginia in 1620 took root and grew with marvellous rapidity until it became an evil more destructive than a pestilence. No event in the history of our country has carried with it to its last analysis such terrible consequences. Nor did slavery confine itself to the colony of Virginia, but it spread in all directions and even reared its head among the sons of the Pilgrims and stalked shamelessly over the hills of New England. Two hundred years before proud, aristocratic, Cavalier Virginia had won for herself the distinguished honor of being called “The Mother of Presidents,” she became the Mother of Slavery.

The northern white man and the southern white man alike became responsible for the pernicious system of serfdom introduced in America. Frederick Douglass said there was but one innocent party to the evil and that was the Negro himself. And as he was the innocent party to his slavery, so he has been since his emancipation the innocent and abused party in all

controversies relating to his privileges as a freeman and to his rights as a citizen.

There have been stirring issues and far-reaching upheavals crowded into the eventful years, and things have moved fast in this country since its first settlement. A great war came and changed the legal relations of its inhabitants and conferred upon them new rights, discharged old bonds and imposed new duties. A people achieved independence and brought into existence a nation. Questions of great import came to the surface; questions of national policy demanding solution, questions that were disposed of in a wise and statesman-like and patriotic way. But there was one question, the like of which had never before harassed a nation. It was how to maintain a democratic form of government of thirty millions of people, of whom twenty millions existed under one kind of social and industrial system and ten millions under another totally different from it. The twenty millions of one race forming one section of the country, carried out to some extent among themselves that portion of the Declaration of Independence touching the equal creation and inalienable rights of man. The ten millions forming the other section consisted in nearly equal portions of two races—one Anglo-Saxon, the other African; one master, the other slave; one the descendants of voluntary emigrants who came hither seeking happiness and a broader freedom; the other deriving their blood from forced emigrants who came to the shores of America and were sold as chattels.

This condition developed the problem which has harassed the country for more than a hundred years. It raised the question which could be answered only in one way, and that was that such an experiment in government with two such conflicting elements could not succeed. Abraham Lincoln answered it, when he said: "Our country cannot exist half slave and half free." The thoughtful men of the nation saw the cloud on the horizon, when it was no bigger than a man's hand. They endeavored to ward off the storm of which it was the precursor, but they were not equal to the task. It grew and grew and became darker and darker, until it finally burst into a tempest, destructive of life and treasure beyond the imagination of man. But this storm was worth all the sacrifice which our country was called upon to suffer, for it carried before it slavery and all its horrors. That glorious storm of shot and shell was sent by the Almighty as a punishment for our

country's greatest crime. It made it possible for us to assemble here tonight as a free people.

Those who associate the movement for the freedom of the Negro only with the northern section of our country forget that in Tennessee the first anti-slavery paper was published, and that in the early years of the nineteenth century it was far safer to deliver a speech against slavery in East Tennessee than in any part of the North. In Thomas Jefferson, Patrick Henry, George Mason and George Wythe, all Virginians, the cause of freedom found uncompromising advocates. It was through the influence of these men that the first Congress of the colonies in 1774 adopted unanimously a covenant against slavery. Thomas Jefferson wrote that portion of the ordinance before the Continental Congress in 1784 which declared for the freedom of the Negro in all territory to be ceded to the new Union by the original states. Unfortunately this section of the resolution was lost, because a delegate from the state of New Jersey, who was in favor of it, was not in his place in Congress when the vote was taken.

Those of us who have studied the passing and conflicting scenes and the bitter partisan struggles in our country for the last century, all growing out of slavery and the awful impress which the system left upon our civilization, can realize what tremendous results may hang upon the vote of a single individual. History relates that as the British ships at Trafalgar started into battle Lord Nelson, the great commander, signaled from the flag-ship this immortal message—"England expects every man to his duty." It may have been the inspiration of these words that brought victory to the British forces that day. If this one delegate had been present when that all important vote was taken on what is now known as the ordinance of 1784, this country would have been spared the bloody drama of the Civil War and the Negro race a half century of a cruel, degrading slavery.

A wonderful lesson there is for us all in the failure of this one man to do his duty. In this hour, I may say, of our peril, when the whole Christian world has its eyes upon him, when all of his faults are magnified and all his virtues depreciated, it becomes necessary for the humblest one among us to do his duty; to live a life that will be above suspicion and that will command the respect of all men.

Though the Continental Congress did pass a law in 1787 prohibiting slavery in the territory of the United States northwest of the Ohio River, the friends of the Negro were not satisfied. They turned to the Constitutional Convention. Here was an august assembly of freemen, composed of the most illustrious statesmen, warriors and patriots of the new nation, presided over by the chieftain who had led its military force to victory. Surely, it was thought the black man would get justice from men who had just won their freedom from the usurpation of the British crown. He deserved to receive it. For, from the opening to the closing of the Revolutionary War, on many fields of strife and triumph, Negroes had fought the battles of the American Nation with a valor no less distinguished than that of their white brothers with whom they passed through that desperate struggle shoulder to shoulder. This is the cold fact of history.

The ill-luck that was with the Negro in the Congress of 1784, when his future was determined by the neglect of one man, followed him to the Constitutional Convention. Unfortunately, two powerful influences for freedom, Thomas Jefferson and John Adams, were not present. They were abroad representing their country at European Courts. The great commoner George Mason of Virginia pleaded for the slave, but in vain. And when slavery tacitly went into the Constitution, like a man and a freeman worthy of the name, he refused to sign it, and walked out of the Convention. He prophesied then that God would finally punish a national sin like slavery by a national calamity. And so He did. The Negro had been a brave soldier in the hour of his country's peril; the Constitutional Convention virtually declared that he was only a chattel in time of his Country's peace.

In the shadows of the expiring days of the eighteenth century an influence for the perpetuation of slavery came from a source least expected. Among other inventions of the period was the cotton gin. It rooted the institution into the very marrow of the political and industrial life of the young Republic. The north began to develop cotton manufactories. It grew lukewarm on the subject of the freedom of the Negro. In the south the slaves increased in value, and slavery took on a new life. From this time on it became darker in its shades of inhumanity and moral degradation. It finally reached a point in its cruelty not far removed from the horrors and terrors of the "Middle Passage." It approached, indeed, that monstrous

maxim which is said to have come from the nation's Supreme Court—"A Negro has no rights which a white man is bound to respect."

But the star of hope had not completely vanished. Massachusetts had declared back in 1780 that no man could stand upon her soil and look upon the towering monuments erected to the memory of her illustrious sons who fell in defense of liberty, and be a slave. Her example was followed by other states, until in 1830 the last northern state freed its slaves.

And now a new crusade against slavery began. Thomas Jefferson, George Mason, Patrick Henry and John Adams had passed away, but their mantles fell on worthy shoulders. There appeared upon the scene men whom God had raised up to create for the country a conscience that would eventually demand the overthrow of slavery. They appealed to the people and invoked their sovereignty as the greatest and most affective force in a democracy.

First came Benjamin Lundy, preaching with vigor and power a gradual emancipation. Contemporaneous with him was William Lloyd Garrison, the radical, demanding nothing less than the immediate and unconditional manumission of slaves. His heroic and undaunted spirit, his earnestness and his uncompromising attitude on the subject of slavery easily made him the leading force among abolitionists. Around and about him were gathered other men imbued with the same sublime and holy sentiments. There were the eloquent Phillips, John Brown, burning with zeal, the learned Sumner, the fearless Lovejoys, our own majestic Frederick Douglass with his tongue of flame, and others equally energetic and equally in earnest. God had given to these men the fires of genius. It took the cause of human liberty to arouse them from their slumbers. Great events make great men.

From 1850 to 1860 the country was all aflame with the slavery agitation. The institution itself was complete master in the halls of national legislation. It prostituted statesmen, and by the Dred Scott decision, the Supreme Court of the United States "clothed it with the ample garments of judicial respectability." Three quarters of a century after the fathers of the country had met in Convention "for the purpose of forming a more perfect union," the great evil slavery brought that union to the very verge of dissolution. The prophesy of Jefferson that slavery would be the rock on which the country would eventually split was fulfilled and the states were in the throes of a Civil War.

There are evils so vast and radical that nothing short of a bloody revolution can be found sufficient to extirpate them. So the eradication of the monstrous system that held four millions of human beings in bondage—a vast property estimated in value at from twelve to fifteen hundred million dollars—was accomplished only by a terrible, devastating war—the court of last resort. From it there was no appeal.

In the beginning of the struggle few believed that the liberation of the slaves would be the outcome. And if it had not been for the obstinate perversity of the South the two sections of the country might have reached an agreement perpetuating slavery in the states in which it then existed and simply forbidding its extension into new territory. The North was perfectly willing that there should be a rehabilitation of the country with southern laws and southern institutions reacknowledged in their old form. But God was in this contest as well as man. He willed it otherwise. The war became so desperate that President Lincoln was forced to issue the Emancipation Proclamation as an imperative measure of self-defense. He did what he had always desired to do, but what he had been kept from doing by northern public opinion—an opinion which the exigencies of the situation had now revolutionized.

This act was soon followed by the arming of colored men for duty as soldiers. No men ever sought more eagerly to fight for any cause than did the black men for the freedom which the Emancipation Proclamation promised. When the opportunity was given them to enlist, they joyfully accepted it, and as the loyal white men had cried two years before, so cried they,

“We are coming, Father Abraham,
Six hundred thousand strong.”

On the brightest pages of the history of the Civil War are written the accounts of their splendid deeds of valor. Port Hudson, Milliken’s Bend, Olustee and Fort Wagner are names that will always be inseparably connected with their glorious achievements in battle. The records tell us that 178,975 colored soldiers took part in 213 battles and skirmishes, and that 36,847 of them lost their lives. Among the men honored by the Congress of the United States with medals for distinguished service in action during the Civil War are seventeen Negroes.

The courage and the spirit of these men are shown in an occurrence which took place immediately after the desperate charge at Fort Wagner, where the sainted Shaw fell at the head of his black regiment. One of the officers went about among the wounded after the battle speaking to them words of encouragement. He finally came upon a large group of men and asked them: "If out of it and at home, how many of you would enlist again?" Every man replied, even the wounded, that he would, and that he would fight until the last brother should break his chains. "For if all our people get their freedom, we can afford to die".

The good and just Abraham Lincoln speaking of the part Negro soldiers bore in the war, paid them this tribute: "There are some Negroes living who can remember, and the children of some who are dead, who will not forget that some black men with steady eye and well poised bayonet helped mankind to save liberty in America."

The condition that faced the country at the close of the Civil War was a sad and serious illustration of the proverb that it is easier to destroy than to create, easier to pull down than to build up. To weld again the states into an harmonious union was a great task, made more difficult by the injection of a problem that was new, grave and without precedent. No nation had ever before been called upon to meet such a situation. Here were four millions of Negroes, recently emancipated, to be in some way absorbed in the body politic. How this could be done to the advantage of the freedmen, their former owners and the country, became a question of national proportions. The situation, too, presented a political phase, complicated by race antagonism, which made the work of the restoration and the reconstruction of the southern states not only difficult, but extremely uncertain. "It was most emphatically untrodden ground, an unexplored sea; and there were neither land-marks nor chart." It was inevitable that whatever was done would be experimental and tentative. And, as if to paralyze and destroy any effort that might be made to adjust conditions so that a permanent peace and prosperity and happiness might follow, fell assassination came and struck down the great emancipator—the man best prepared to guide the ship of state through such difficulties and dangers.

It is easy enough for the men of our time to criticise, to find fault with and to underrate the efforts of the statesmen of forty years ago who devised the plan for the reconstruction of the states which had been in rebellion. But

when one considers the intrinsic difficulties of the situation, he cannot but be impressed with the patriotism, the justice and the earnestness of purpose of such men as Charles Sumner, Thaddeus Stevens and Oliver P. Morton. The splendid legislation which their giant intellects matured and their indefatigable efforts helped to enact is the best evidence of their power of perception, foresight and judgment. The whole country owes a debt of gratitude to the superb statesmanship of these men, but the Negro race is preeminently the beneficiary of their mighty thoughts and prodigious labors. For out of the conflicts of purposes and plans for rebuilding a shattered nation, there were evolved with their aid the three great war amendments, guaranteeing to the Negro freedom, citizenship and the elective franchise. To weave into the organic law these marks of manhood for the black man was a fit return of a grateful country for the support he had given it in time of its distress. He had protected the government with the bayonet, it was right he should be granted the privilege of serving it with the ballot.

The 13th amendment legally abolished slavery, and, strange as it may seem, this provision of the organic law, brought the word "slavery" into the constitution for the first time. The 14th amendment prescribed citizenship for the Negro, and the 15th amendment put into his hands the ballot as a weapon of defense against those who were cruelly persecuting him. For it is a part of the history of the period immediately following the Civil War that "Black codes" were enacted in some of the southern states, so awful in their effect that the poor freedmen were reduced to a condition not far removed from slavery itself.

None but those who can recall these days of terror can fully appreciate what the elective franchise did for the Negro at that time. Under the circumstances, freedom for him without the ballot would have been the merest mockery. The terrible persecutions inflicted upon loyal white men and upon Negroes determined Congress as Oliver P. Morton said, "in the last resort, and as the last thing to be done, to dig through all the rubbish, dig through the soil and the shifting sands and go down to the eternal rock, and there upon the basis of the everlasting principle of equal and exact justice to all men, plant the column of reconstruction." The charge that Congress intended to establish Negro political supremacy in the southern states is false. For, if it had been the purpose of Congress to do this, the

suggestion of Charles Sumner would have been adopted and all men who had been concerned in the rebellion would have been excluded from the suffrage. "Negro domination" has always been a false alarm and a myth. It has never existed. Even when the black man's vote was honestly counted it was cast so as to make the white man the dominating influence in the political life of the state.

It is a popular thing nowadays to say that the ballot was given the Negro too soon, or he would be better off, if it had not been given him at all. I know not by what system of reasoning these conclusions are reached. For "freedom is the school in which freemen are taught, and the ballot box is the educator." A man must have his political rights, in order to protect his natural rights. It is most fortunate that the elective franchise was given to the Negro so soon after his emancipation. At that time, the North, at least, was friendly to him. It looked upon him as a ward. But when we consider the attitude of hostility which the white American in all parts of the country has assumed towards the colored American in recent years, we must conclude that if the ballot had not already been given him, it would not be granted for a long time to come.

It will take time, it will require tact, self restraint and infinite patience on the part of the colored people to create a public sentiment which will finally assure them a fair and honest exercise of the ballot. They are only forty years removed from slavery. It is not a day in the life of a people. We are told that it took the Romans three centuries and a half of hard fighting to get control of the principalities about them, measuring only twenty-four miles around. But when they once got a foothold, they began their conquests, and did not stop until the world was subject to Rome's domination.

The Negro has had his day of mushroom growth. It was one of sad experiences. He is beginning life again and moving along the lines of a natural evolution. He will win his way, not by statutes so much as by a public sentiment which will see that he gets equal and exact justice as a man and as a citizen. This may be the work of years, but the day will come when we shall see its accomplishment. There will no longer be one law for the Negro and one for the white man; one Constitution for the North and one for the South. What Charles Sumner said will then be true in practice as well as in theory: "It is vain to say this is the country of the white man. It is the country of man."

Three centuries ago the ancestors of American Negroes were savages, inhabiting a vast continent dark with the shadow of an unrecorded past. Today the descendants of these savages dwelling in our country number ten millions. They have come in contact with a great civilization and have absorbed its elements with a marvellous rapidity. They have learned to work, have acquired the language and adopted the religion of a great people. The world knows amid what trials and sacrifices all of this has been accomplished. Though his new life and upward career did not begin until 1865, the Negro has impressed the country with his innate worth as a factor in a great civilization. He has thoroughly vindicated his capacity for indefinite improvement. The beneficiary of a splendid philanthropy, he has more than justified the hopes of his friends, and he has belied the predictions of his foes. The material progress of the former slaves in forty years is one of the marvels of a wonderful country. They have 130,000 farms worth \$400,000,000; homes, not including the farms mentioned, valued at \$325,000,000, and personal property worth \$165,000,000, making a grand total of \$899,000,000 which they present to the world for their first generation of freedom.

The race has developed in the meantime 30,000 school teachers, 700 physicians and more than 700 lawyers. There are 1,800,000 Negro children enrolled in the schools; 40,000 students in higher institutions of learning; 30,000 students learning trades; 12,000 pursuing classical courses; 12,000 taking scientific courses and 1,000 in business courses. 40,000 young men and women have graduated from secondary institutions of learning and 4,000 from colleges. The Negro has \$12,000,000 worth of school property, and church property valued at \$40,000,000.

The capacity, the thrift and the frugality of the black man need no encomium. The record speaks for itself. In its comment on similar statistics the Boston Herald recently said, "When we think that forty years ago the Negroes were the poorest people on the face of the earth, that their only home was the wide, wide world and their roof was an expanse of blue sky, is it not wonderful that within a short generation they have not only been able to house and clothe themselves and children, but to educate in part nearly one half of their number, and still pile up a large competence to lay by for a rainy day."

The progress of the Negro since his emancipation is a marvellous story. It reflects credit upon himself and it is a lasting tribute to the Northern philanthropists and those broad-minded Southerners who environed him with effective helps and valuable opportunities, and who gave him such stimulating encouragement. By and through these elements the Negro has been able to give a striking evidence of his ability for a self-developing American citizenship.

And yet, all of his splendid progress in education and all of the useful qualities developed in him as an industrial factor have not protected him against terrible outrages and unspeakable cruelties. When he was eliminated from the field of politics by state constitutions, adopted for that sole purpose, it was our hope and prayer that he would at least find some compensation for the wrong in safety from the mob and in the enjoyment of that peace which should attend every law abiding citizen, whether white or black. Our hopes have not been realized and we are forced to the conclusion that the brutal treatment of the Negro is not due to the fact that he was in politics. Nothing less than an intolerant race hatred could be the moving influence of such ferocity and fiendishness as characterize the lynchings of the black man in this country. Where Negroes are concerned mob law too often has displaced judges and juries and terrorized sheriffs and done away with prison walls. Its ravages are confined to no section of the country. Occasionally white men are the victims of its awful fury—but only for the most terrible crimes; but let the Negro's offence be great or small, he is not secure from its vengeance. Our enemies succeeded for a long time in making the country believe that the black man was lynched only for the unspeakable crime. The record has always belied this charge. Bishop Candler of the Southern Methodist Church said the other day that two years ago the figures for a year showed only sixteen cases of rape against 128 lynchings. He gave, too, this significant warning, "If the people will not control the mob, the mob will soon control the people." That best and fairest of men President Roosevelt, sees the danger. He knows that they who violate the rights of one race of men, unrestrained, will soon violate the rights of another. In his own vigorous way he has spoken to the country on the subject of mob law. It is to be hoped that one speaking from so exalted a place will arouse the American conscience from the slumber into which it has been lulled by an unconcern dangerous to individuals and to the country alike. Referring to the crime of rape he has given us the wisest and best

advice. "In such cases," says he "the colored people throughout the land should in every possible way show their belief that they, more than all others in the community are horrified at the commission of such crime and are peculiarly concerned in taking every possible measure to prevent its recurrence and bring the criminal to immediate justice. The slightest lack of vigor, either in denunciation of the crime or in bringing the criminal to justice is itself unpardonable." In his wisdom the President has struck the note to which we must readily and willingly respond. No man, black or white, who commits a crime is entitled to our sympathy or to our protection. It is our duty both in speech and in conduct to endeavor to impress the communities in which we live with two things; first, that we are unalterably opposed to mob law; secondly, that we are anxious to have Negro criminals punished, but in accordance with legal methods.

Unfortunately and unjustly, the white man chooses to judge the whole Negro race by its bad, vicious, shiftless, unreliable members. He does not measure it by the multitude who have learned and who practice the common moralities of every day life. He does not take into account that there are thousands of black men and women among us who have made for themselves a place among the most orderly and the most industrious elements in their communities. For some reason it seems to suit the purpose of a great and powerful people with all of the machinery of publication and circulation under their control to expose to the world and to emphasize the faults of the Negro.

It cannot be denied that the Negro has made remarkable progress along all lines of commendable endeavor since his emancipation. Yet he is but an infant, in the larger sense, in the industrial world. This is the most serious part of his problem, for he belongs almost exclusively to the laboring class. In the country he is the farm hand and in the city he is the domestic servant, for the most part, and common laborer. Except in the South he is rarely employed as a mechanic. The white men of the North have persistently and successfully kept him out of the trades. And worse than that they are driving him out of the menial occupations which are his very existence. This exclusion from domestic service the Negro cannot charge to prejudice on account of color. The truth is, competition is becoming so keen in other branches of employment that a good class of intelligent white men and women are forced into these humble walks of life for a livelihood. They put

brains into the work which the Negro too often foolishly despises. They elevate it from unskilled to skilled labor. It is easy enough to forecast the result of such a situation. The employer will get the best labor possible for his money. He is not going to hire an incompetent man, when he can get a competent one at the same price.

Once out of his usual occupations, there is nothing for the Negro to do. He becomes an idler subjected to all of the dangers and vices of his condition. Crime is sure to follow idleness. Unless the Negroes endeavor to excel in all branches of work in which they are employed they will be driven out of them, and no one can tell how far reaching will be the result. This matter is of vital interest, not only to the people themselves directly concerned, but also to the Negro tradesmen and Negro professional men who are dependent upon them for a living. The lawyers, doctors, teachers, preachers and the men in business cannot escape the logic of the situation. In this practical age the laborer must in truth be worthy of his hire.

Through the public press the news comes to us that in Germany schools are being established in which waiters are trained. In addition to the art of becoming skilled in their trade, they are taught the English and French languages. These efficient and well schooled servants are coming to America from time to time in large numbers. It is not to be expected that the unskilled Negro waiters can successfully compete with these men. Sentiment in their favor may save them for a while, but not for all time. Cooks, chambermaids and nurses among the whites are similarly drilled. Unless the colored people dependent upon these vocations for a living adopt like methods of training, they will awake some morning and find these occupations in the cities gone from them. A proper appreciation for work, a respect for labor of all kinds on the part of the Negro may save him from this calamity.

The most encouraging fact touching the Negro's present condition is his deep and earnest interest in education. His conduct in this respect is beyond all praise. He cannot be held responsible in any way for the illiteracy that exists among his race. Slavery is the plain historical cause of this misfortune.

Though the colored people have made commendable progress in education, yet they have not reached a point that justifies them in quibbling

and splitting hairs as to the kind of education the schools should give them. Let them be sure to make good use of what they do get. As a race they are sadly, very sadly in need of that training so eloquently advocated by Booker T. Washington. The men and women who are to be teachers and who purpose to enter the professions will find a way to get a training which will fit them for their work. But they are the few in any race. In the present stage of their development the colored people need to concern themselves especially about the great multitude among them who can only get, at most, the veriest rudiments of education. The time has not yet come among Negroes for "The Battle of the Books."

In conclusion let me commend your effort to celebrate this day—a day which every man in this country with Negro blood in his veins should bless and hallow. Though September 22, 1862, was only the day of the announcement, yet it is hardly of less importance than the day of the actual issuance of the proclamation of freedom. We reverence the memory of Abraham Lincoln, the great emancipator. For before he gave to the world the great charter of liberty, no Negro in America had rights or privileges worthy of the name.

The black man has not been ungrateful for this act, nor for any other consideration which his country has ever shown him. In all of the Nation's wars his blood has crimsoned every great battle field, from Bunker Hill in Massachusetts to San Juan Hill in Cuba. And nowhere in history is it recorded that he ever dishonored or disgraced the uniform of a United States Soldier. He has been no less faithful in peace than he was brave in war. He has been law-abiding and industrious; "he has been as patient as the earth beneath and as the stars above." Some day his right to life, liberty and happiness will be granted in all its fullness.

"For freedom's battle once begun,
Bequeathed from bleeding sire to son,
Though baffled oft, is ever won."

- Transcriber's Notes:

- Missing or obscured punctuation was silently corrected.
- Typographical errors were silently corrected.
- Inconsistent spelling and hyphenation were made consistent only when a predominant form was found in this book.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK A GLANCE AT
THE PAST AND PRESENT OF THE NEGRO: AN ADDRESS ***

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